that he was too close to Aung San Suu Kyi and was likely to facilitate a post-election deal favourable to the NLD. Subsequently, Shwe Mann has openly met Aung San Suu Kyi,[33] fuelling suspicions of a deal between a faction of the USDP and the NLD. There is evidence in support of this interpretation, as Shwe Mann has been described as an 'ally' by Aung San Suu Kyi: 'Now the picture is clearer as to who is a friend and an enemy, and our relationship with our allies is stronger'. The NLD, she said, would 'work with the ally'.[34]

From the available information, Shwe Mann was also open to some revisions of the 2008 Constitution to remove military privileges that it enshrined.[35] In turn, indicating how opaque Myanmar politics has become, some commentators suggest that both the promises of reform and his apparent overtures to the NLD should be seen purely in terms of internal USDP factional disputes.[36] In effect, gaining a reputation as a potential reformer might have helped Shwe Mann to become more powerful than Thein Sein. Since he was also seen as being closer than the latter to the deposed Than Shwe, his fall should be seen as the public face of a power struggle within the military.

That this might be the case is also backed up by the fact that the USDP has slowly been repositioning itself less as a party of retired officers and more as a normal political party, which has made many elements from within the army officer corps unhappy. However, the USDP has not resolved its underlying problem of a lack of popular support and the elections since 2010 have indicated that it cannot rely on sufficient votes from military or state employees to offset the NLD's popularity. Thus, the position of the military is partly threatened by the outcome of the 2015 election, in which the USDP lost almost all of the seats it took in the 2010 elections, when the NLD did not contest most districts. As such, some factions of the USDP have been looking for a means to remain in power by doing a deal with the NLD.[37] Of course, as in the period after 1990, the threat of a major electoral defeat raises the fear of a military coup.

If this were to happen, it would help the military if it could present this to the outside world not as sour grapes over electoral defeat but as a necessary step to avert chaos. In effect, a post-election rise in tensions in, for example, Rakhine might be very convenient for the military as a justification to ignore the results and, instead, maintain their own power.